

Mending FENCES

India reaches out to the Awami League in a fresh effort at restoring good relations but tricky issues remain



| By Saurabh Shukla |

Two months ago when a senior official in India's High Commission in Dhaka got a call from his Bangladesh counterpart about a 'gift' he had for him, he was surprised, given that the festive season was far away and the usual bumpy bilateral relationship was still under repair. Some days later when the gift arrived at a dusty outpost in Petrapole on the Indo-Bangla border, it turned out to be a terror fugitive sought by India, who came blindfolded, not gift-wrapped. This was a step forward as even though the present Awami League Government led by Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina had been sensitive to India's security concerns, it was the first time a terror fugitive sought by the country had been handed over.

Since then India has been given "packages"—the code for wanted

terrorists—which contained many militants from the insurgent groups of the North-east. Some even belonged to the Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Toiba. Even though officials were tightlipped about the handovers, a senior intelligence official confirmed that Bangladesh had been cooperating. "We have given them a list of 97 terrorist camps and they have raided some of them in Chittagong and Mymensingh. The initiative has been slow but it is a work in progress," he said.

But what has caused this turnaround and why is this important for India's security interests? The present Government led by Hasina is a moderate one which wants to end the scourge of terrorism in the country. It also realises that it can benefit by having friendly relations with India. With a 4,096-km-long border and a cocktail of contentious issues, including security, trade, transit and water, Bangladesh ranks high on India's



KRISHNA WITH MONI (LEFT); INDIA SHARES A 4,096-KM-LONG BORDER WITH BANGLADESH

strategic radar. A friendly Government in Dhaka is pivotal for the country's security interests given that only 800 km of the border has been fenced and many anti-India groups have taken shelter in Bangladesh. Besides, India realises that to meet its aspirations of playing to a larger global arena, it has to first set things right in the neighbourhood.

This message was amplified on September 8 when the new Foreign Minister of Bangladesh Dipu Moni came to Delhi for talks with External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna. While Delhi thanked Dhaka for its support, Krishna also flagged India's concerns, especially that of the 10 top guns on its list, including ULFA leaders Paresh Barua and Anup Chetia. "We have expressed our concerns and